

LORAIN

High Schools

Quick start propels Admiral King past Vermilion

By BOB MIGRA
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Admiral King coach John Rositano and Vermilion coach Bob Walsh agreed that the first quarter was the key in the Admirals' 73-58 Erie Shore Conference victory last night.

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But they did a basketball version of the chicken-and-the-egg theory afterward. "We were working extremely hard on defense," Rositano said. "We took them out of what they wanted to do."

The Admirals came up with six steals and forced eight turnovers, taking a 10-point lead with more than a minute to go in the first quarter.

Walsh had a little different spin on his team's rough start.

"We kind of gave them that good start," Walsh said. "Between turning the ball over and giving them free shots, we gave them a good start. They jumped, and we were the jumper cables."

Whether it was great defense by the Admirals or a lackluster start by the Sailors, Vermilion was never able to recover, as Admiral King built its lead to 40-17 with three minutes remaining in the second quarter.

"So far this year, we haven't been getting off to good starts," Admiral King guard Alberto Arroyo said. "We knew it was important to get off to a good start."

Scott Bennett's foul-line jump

shot gave the Sailors a 2-0 lead, but it didn't last long, and it was the only lead the home team would enjoy.

Arroyo answered with a 3-point basket on the Admirals' next possession, starting a flurry of 3-pointers.

Tim Torrence came back with a 3-pointer to give the Admirals a 6-2 lead, and Rashad Hanibal's 3-pointer gave Admiral King a 17-9 lead.

Arroyo, who finished with 18 points, scored the Admirals' last two field goals in the first quarter, both 3-point shots, for a 23-12 lead.

The Admirals had to know things were going their way on Arroyo's 3-pointer at the first-quarter buzzer. Arroyo picked up

a loose ball after a missed shot and launched an off-balance shot from the right side, three feet beyond the 3-point arc. Arroyo tumbled over Vermilion's David Cyrek after the shot.

"I just threw it up," Arroyo said. "That was luck, but I'm glad it went in."

A field goal by Doug Taylor and another 3-pointer by Arroyo got the Admirals rolling in the second quarter. The Admirals made 9 of 16 3-point attempts after going 1-for-24 in the first three games.

"We have the guys who can put the ball in the basket," Rositano said. "If they have the shot and they're squared up to the basket, I give them the green light to stroke it."

The Admirals were stroking

from all angles, shooting 58 percent (29-for-50) overall. Doug Taylor led the inside attack, scoring 19 points. Torrence had 14 points and Hanibal 13, including a reverse slam dunk in the third quarter that brought the Admiral King bench to its feet.

Rositano said he was impressed by Taylor's dominance inside.

"When Doug comes out to play, there aren't many guys around who can play with him," Rositano said. "His confidence is very high. He's going to be tough to be stopped."

Admiral King built its lead to 44-22, getting two foul shots by Taylor to cap the first-half scoring.

"We're getting used to what [Rositano] wants us to do now," Taylor said. "We came out a little

bit flat in the first game [a loss to Toledo Libbey], and that woke us up. We're playing together, and we're playing hard now."

After taking a 59-37 lead through three quarters, Admiral King put the game away with seven consecutive field goals early in the fourth quarter.

The Admirals improved to 3-1 overall, 2-0 in the ESC. Vermilion fell to 3-2, 0-1 in the conference.

The Sailors were playing their second game without leading scorer Hubie Bartlett, who was ejected in a victory over Port Clinton for pushing an opposing player, but Walsh wouldn't blame the loss on his absence.

Bartlett, who was averaging 20 points a game, will be eligible to return for next week's ESC game at Elyria.

One-hit wonder

Walsh player's 3-pointer lifts team over SVSM

By BOB DOLGAN
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Matt Kraninger buried his only basket of the game, a 3-pointer, with 1:40 left to lead Walsh Jesuit past St. Vincent-St. Mary, 67-63, in an independent high school game last night.

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Kraninger's heave from the left side put the Warriors ahead, 64-63, for the first time since they scored the opening basket.

"It was the biggest shot I ever hit," said the gleeful Kraninger, a senior. "Jaron Barbee threw me the ball and I just let it go. It felt good right away. I was 0-for-4 or 0-for-5 before that, but we're taught to shoot when we're open. I didn't even think about it. I'm pretty inconsistent. They go in one time and out the other. I'm only averaging about five points a game. The crowd went crazy."

After Kraninger connected, John King missed a jumper with a minute left for the Irish. Then, 6-10 Neil Yanke, who scored 17 points, hit a foul shot to stretch Walsh's lead to 65-63 with 51 seconds remaining.

St. Vincent's Bobby Pridgen, who sank six 3-pointers and scored 20 points, missed on another three with 14 seconds left, and then Jeff Welsh of the Warriors, who scored 20 points, wrapped it up with two foul shots with six seconds to go.

Walsh scored the final 11 points, coming back from a 63-56 deficit.

"It's always a memorable game when we play St. V.," Walsh coach Frank Lupica said. "There's nothing like it. Those last 14 seconds were the longest of my life."

The coach praised Kraninger. "He's a great kid," Lupica said. "He's got a 4.3 grade-point average, he's in the student council and he's a starting safety in football. I've known him forever. Two of his brothers played for me and he was our water boy."

Mitch Gerycz, the St. Vincent-St. Mary coach, whose club has lost four games by a total of 12 points, said, "We took a couple of poor shots down the stretch and they executed well."

"We shot only nine foul shots and that's not a good sign. We need to be more aggressive offensively when we have the lead."

St. Vincent-St. Mary played without sophomore Derrick Tarver, one of the team's leading scorers. But his twin, Darren, scored 16 points. Jaimar Mansel scored 13 for the Irish.

St. Vincent-St. Mary jumped to a 23-14 lead after one quarter as Pridgen hit four 3-pointers.

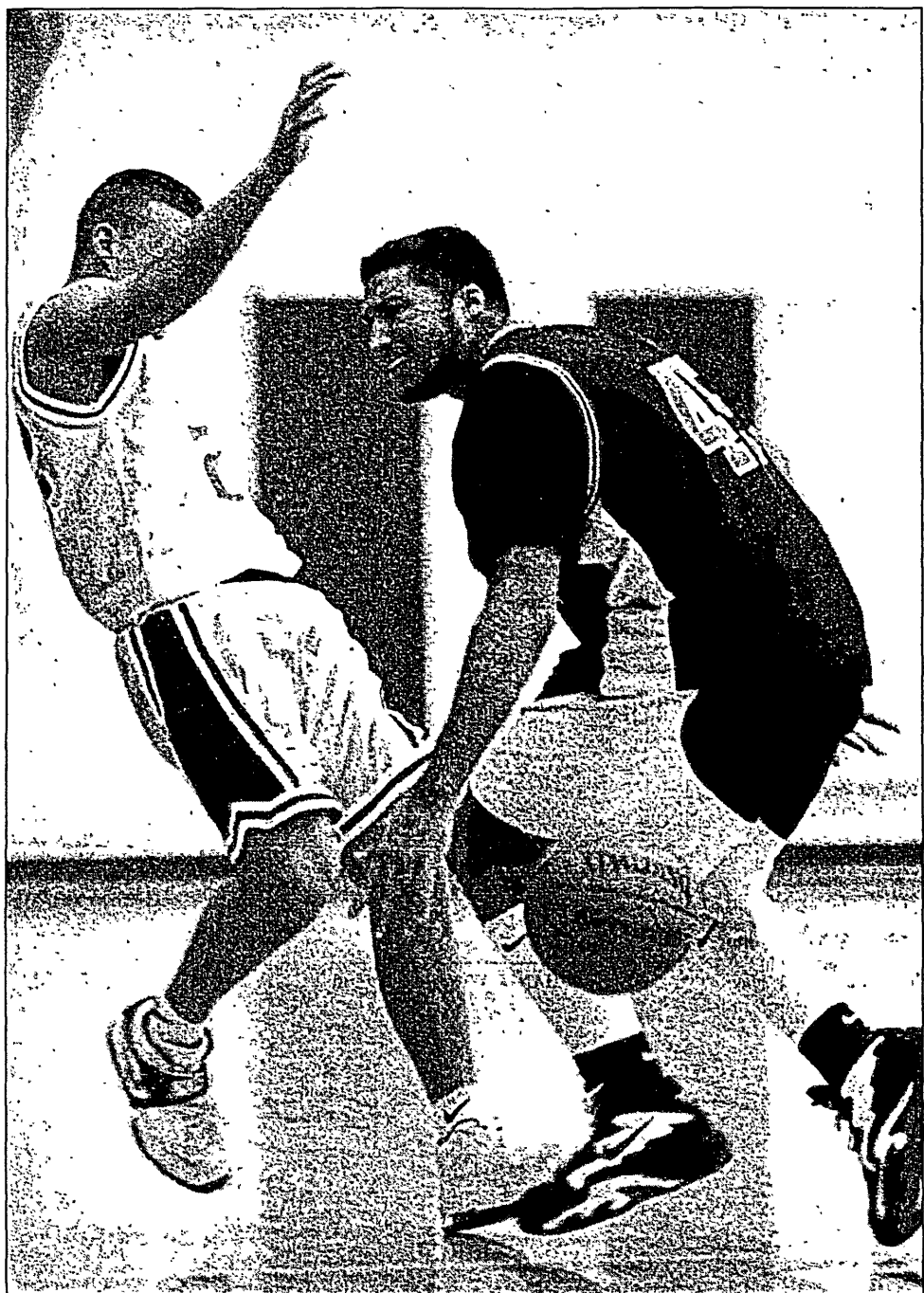
The Irish led, 30-20, in the second period when Walsh went on a 9-2 run to cut it to 32-29. Barbee scored five points in the spree and Welsh and Yanke each had two.

Tarver hit two baskets and Mansel another as St. Vincent-St. Mary rebounded to 38-31. But Welsh scored a basket and Pat O'Brien sank a 3-pointer to cut it to 38-36 at halftime. Barbee held Pridgen scoreless in the second period.

With Tarver making two pretty passes on the fast break, St. Vincent-St. Mary moved to a 49-40 lead in the third, but Welsh scored five and Aaron Powers hit a 3-pointer to cut it to 49-48.

The Irish seemed to have the game under control when Pridgen hit a 3-pointer and a jumper and Tarver and Mansel scored for a 63-56 lead.

But Welsh sank a foul shot and made a steal to cut it to 63-59 and set the stage for the final heroics. Yanke had nine points in the last quarter.



RAMON MENA OWENS / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Mike Collier, left, of Clearview collides with Chris Hougland of Oberlin while battling for a loose ball last night.

Olmsted Falls stays unbeaten with victory over Rocky River

By DICK ZUNT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

It was a night to remember in the Olmsted Falls gymnasium.

Keyed by 6-8 senior Tim Schaefer, the host Bulldogs stayed unbeaten, winning their third Southwestern Conference game and fifth overall, 59-49, last night over Rocky River.

As the Bulldogs kept their share of the conference lead, Rocky River lost for the first time in three SWC games and five games overall.

Schaefer, the MVP of the conference last year when his team won the title with a 14-0 record, surpassed the 1,000-point plateau in his fourth season of varsity basketball.

Schaefer, who became a starter about halfway through his freshman season, led all scorers with 28 points — 18 in the first half. His career total is 1,027.

Schaefer sank a layup from the left side of the basket with the game 11 seconds old for the game's first points. The field goal put him over the magic number.

Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue wanted Schaefer to score his 1,000th point at home. In the previous game, last Friday at Amherst Steele, Donahue took

Schaefer out of the game (after he had scored 30 points) so that he could hit the milestone in front of the home fans.

"We got him out with about three minutes to go at Amherst," said Donahue, whose Bulldogs earned him victory No. 100 (at the school) in that game. "We wanted him to get it in front of a home crowd."

Schaefer then banked in another field goal from the right side for a 4-0 lead at 5:38.

Schaefer then passed to his "twin tower" teammate, 6-9 Jim Kalemba for another layup and slipped through the key and spun in another field goal off the glass for an 8-0 lead with 4:42 remaining.

Rocky River, although it gave away several inches inside, scrapped its way to a 12-12 tie at the end of the first quarter, with its big basket being a 3-pointer by 6-0 junior Connell Dolan.

Olmsted Falls squeezed ahead, 26-25, by halftime. As soon as the intermission began, Donahue called Schaefer's parents, Danny and Gerry, to midcourt near the scorers' table and presented the game ball to them. Tim kissed his mother and hugged his father, and adjourned to the locker room while they returned to the stands.

The third quarter was another tense eight minutes and ended with the score tied, 37-37, after

the Bulldogs' Kalemba sank a layup with 0:03 left. Schaefer had cut the inside of his lip at 4:50 of the third quarter and missed a few minutes of play.

Kalemba converted two free throws at 7:23 of the fourth quarter to put his team ahead, and the Bulldogs were able to finally build a 10-point lead in the last two minutes.

Schaefer scored all his second-half points (including 8-of-8 from the foul line) in the last 2:07. Rocky River's Dolan, who led his team with 17 points, hit two 3-point field goals in the last 1:31.

"My main goal tonight was to win the game," said Schaefer. "I figured that I would score at least one point, but winning the game was all I wanted to do."

"We figured Tim's 1,000th would come early since we like to get the ball to him," said Donahue. "The kids played hard and both teams did a nice job. Our team with its size tends to wear the opponent down."

"[Schaefer] is strong more than he is tall," Rocky River coach Jim Rucki said. "We could not handle him. It's tough to press when he's in there."

"They made the plays down the stretch and we didn't," said Rucki.

Rocky River's Jeff Peate scored 13 points and Kalemba and John Storey each finished with 11 for the Bulldogs.

Oberlin's rally beats Clearview

Defense leads to 70-67 victory

By JACK McDERMOTT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Oberlin High turned a strong second-half defensive effort into a come-from-behind victory, beating the stunned Clippers, 70-67, last night at Clearview in Lorain County Conference play.

BOYS BASKETBALL

"I'm elated with the way my kids came back," said Oberlin coach Joe Harris, as the Indians climbed to 4-2 overall, 2-0 in the LCC.

"We could have folded our tents and gave up near the end of the first half, but we didn't. Instead, we hung with them through bad times, and before it was all over, we'd turned the momentum in our favor."

Oberlin trailed, 42-30, with 1:36 remaining in the first half, following a lay-in by Clearview's Chris Hitchens. Oberlin then outscored the Clippers, 6-2, down the stretch with two baskets by senior Chris Hougland and a tip-in at the buzzer by senior Mario Gibbs, cutting the Clearview lead to 44-36 at the intermission.

Hougland scored 17 of his game-high 26 points in the first half, including three first-quarter 3-pointers, to keep the Indians' hopes alive.

"We went over a few things at halftime," Harris said, "then we went back out and turned the tide."

"We wanted to force them into speeding up their offense and get them to turn the ball over. Clearview has some very talented players, but they're not used to running the floor as quickly as we forced them to tonight."

"I also felt we'd given them the baseline too much in the first half and they scored 12 points off us as a result. That's where our defense stepped in."

With 5-10 junior guard Jeff Chambers leading the way with eight third-quarter points, the Indians battled back to take a 50-49 lead with 3:02 left in the third period.

Clearview responded with 6-5 senior Eric Gilbert connecting on a 3-pointer from the right sideline, then adding two free throws before senior teammate Mike Collier scored a lay-in with 29 seconds remaining to give Clearview a 56-50 edge at the close of the third quarter.

Clearview's last hurrah came with 4:05 left in the contest, as Gilbert scored from underneath to give the Clippers a 63-58 cushion. Oberlin then turned on the afterburners, outscoring the Clippers, 9-0, over the next 2:17 to hold a 67-63 lead with 1:22 to play, following a basket by Chambers.

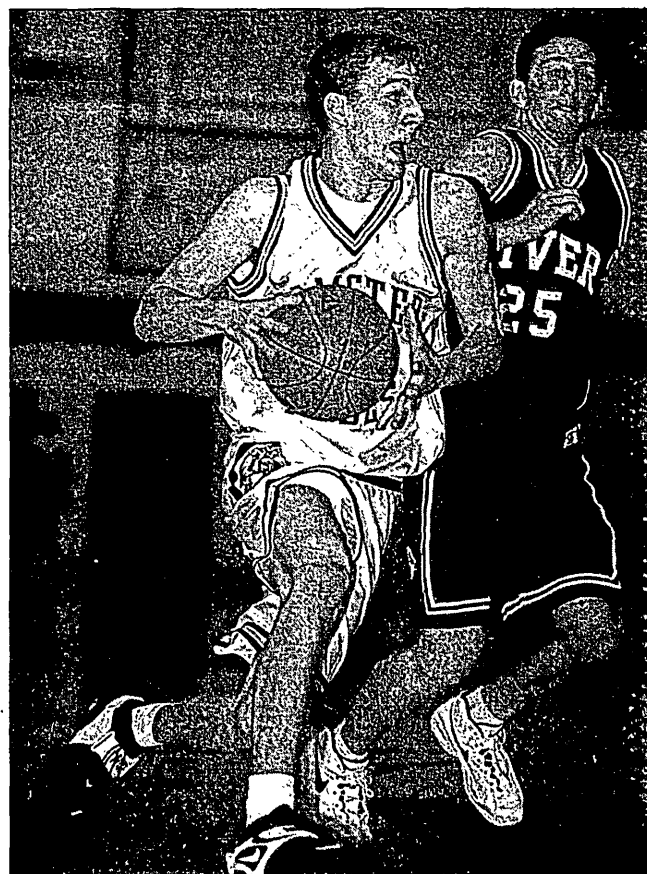
With Gilbert connecting on 1 of 2 free-throw attempts, followed by a basket by Hitchens, the Clippers narrowed the Indians' lead to 67-66 with 41 seconds remaining. Chambers then iced the Oberlin win, connecting on 1-of-2 free throws with 24 seconds left, putting Oberlin on top, 68-66. Junior Jermaine Holt capped the scoring with two free throws, his only points of the night, with two seconds remaining.

Gilbert led Clearview with 24 points; Hitchens finished with 18.

"They made us play their style of ball," said a dejected Clearview coach John Szalay. "Even when we had a 12-point lead, we never had a handle on the tempo of the game. From beginning to end, we never played smart basketball and we never showed any discipline. Let's face it, we had the lead for most of the game, but we never had control of what was going on."

"Then, in the end, we had several chances to pull it out, but we missed our shots and committed turnovers. I think a lot of the kids got hooked into believing all the preseason hype. Maybe now that we've lost a game, maybe we'll see how good a team we actually have. I'm interested in how we respond," Szalay said.

The Clippers (3-1 overall, 1-1 in the LCC) won't have long to wait for Szalay's answer, as Clearview plays host to Lorain Catholic tonight.



ELIZABETH MALBY / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Olmsted Falls' Sean Radigan drives past Rocky River's Sean Kennedy last night.